Just Stop Oil co-founder floats council tax strike in Lambeth

Roger Hallam addresses the assembly (Brixton Buzz)

By Alex Levy, 30.10.25

Activist Roger Hallam launched a citizens' assembly at a public meeting in Brixton last night, calling for a council tax strike and predicting a rout of Labour candidates in next year's local elections.

'Assemble Brixton' met in a public gathering of over 100 local residents at Karibu Education Centre, following seven assemblies during October which recorded residents' perception of homelessness, mental health and addiction in Lambeth.

Thursday's assembly aimed to decide on demands to be presented to Lambeth Council, but did not reach a conclusion due to dissent among those present, including around the suggestion of a council tax strike.

Attendees took issue with the timeline proposed by organisers, which many felt was unrealistic. The organisers wanted to poll residents in January, at which point if 25% of those surveyed on the doorstep did not think these problems were 'sorted', the assembly would take action against the council.

Many attendees also expressed confusion at the group's origins and motivations, including heckling organiser Chris Chudley and assembly facilitators about whether they in fact lived in Lambeth.

Mr Hallam suggested three courses of action: a petition, a rally, and a tax strike. Addressing the assembly, he said: "Some people are going, hang on a minute, we're paying all these council taxes, why don't we not pay council tax for a few weeks?"

“It’s not about doing anything illegal, it’s not about depriving the council of money. It’s about making a point in the public sphere,” he added. At this point, several attendees interrupted Mr Hallam to point out that not paying council tax is illegal.

He also floated the prospect of standing independent candidates, saying: “In January and February, if, with all due respect, the Labour councillors have not got what they said they were going to do done, then some people, whether we want them or not, will start standing as independent.”

“I have no particular problem with the Labour party per se, but the fact of the matter is they don’t have a divine right to rule Brixton”.

David Bridson, Labour councillor for Lambeth, addressed the assembly to explain the council’s ongoing work on the issues of homelessness, mental health and addiction.

He said: “We support 200 people every single year from the streets into accommodation, and every single night there are a minimum of 40 beds in hotels in Clapham waiting for those people when they’re ready to say yes to us.”

He stressed the difficulties with timelines in social work, saying: “Trauma affects all of our rough sleepers in a very dramatic way. A lot of them are leaving prison, they’ve been care leavers, they’re from the armed forces.

“We don’t solve that overnight. We visit them every single night because hopefully one day, once we build that relationship, they’ll be ready to say yes to come indoors”.

When asked about the proposed council tax strike after the meeting, Mr Bridson said: “It won’t change anything. You will have a bailiff at your door and it will change nothing.”

“We have no money as a council anyway, and fundamentally, there’s hardly much more we can do other than the public engaging more within that process.”

Speaking after the meeting, Mr Hallam said: “It’s a live issue, so you expect emotion in the room.

“What will happen in [the assembly] is nothing compared to what people are saying on the doorstep about the terrible stories of people’s suffering and the degradation of life on the streets. It’s just awful.”

Asked if he envisioned civil disobedience arising from the launch of the assembly, Mr Hallam said: “I think there are lots of communities around the country that are on the edge of doing rent strikes, not paying their council taxes.”

He said the United Kingdom’s history is full of acts of civil disobedience, saying it happens when people decide they won’t tolerate “ridiculous levels of injustice”.

“People don’t do civil disobedience because their bin hasn’t been collected, they do civil disobedience because they feel violated.”

He said there has been a movement towards anti-incumbency and local communities are looking to move out of the established political system.

He mentioned Your Party, for which he expressed strong support in an interview with *The New Statesman* in August of this year, and the Green Party as possible ‘anti-system’ beneficiaries of this dissatisfaction.

Regarding the local elections in May 2026, Mr Hallam said: “For my money, maybe I shouldn’t say this, but I don’t care, I don’t think it’s entirely impossible that there could be 20 or 30 non-Labour councillors in Lambeth. They could lose their majority in May.”

Mr Hallam was released from HMP Wayland on 14 August this year having served a reduced four-year sentence for conspiring to disrupt traffic on the M25 in 2022.

Assembly attendee and local resident, Lily-Rose Morris-Zumin, said: “It’s clear there is a real desire to help the homeless and underprivileged in Brixton, even without consensus on how to achieve that.

“I feel the organisers could have been more transparent about their origins and who is backing the assembly.”

Following the launch, the aims decided at the meeting will be written up as a ‘community charter’ and a rally will be held outside Lambeth Town Hall on 24 November.